
The 8 Greatest Sci-Fi Book Trilogies of All Time, Ranked

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The 8 Greatest Sci-Fi Book Trilogies of All Time, Ranked

[Sci-fi has always been about thinking on a grand scale](#). By the genre's very nature, sometimes an author's ideas can't be contained comfortably in one book. As a result, [science fiction](#) has produced more than a few phenomenal trilogies, from the multi-century sweep of *Foundation* to the hard sci-fi suspense of *The Three-Body Problem*.

The book series below are all creative and ambitious, whether rooted in political intrigue, cyberpunk dystopia, action-packed space opera, or philosophical allegory. They should contain something for every kind of sci-fi fan, and the fact that they come in threes should be a bonus for anyone who loves both the genre and literature as a whole.

8 Mars Trilogy (1992–1999)

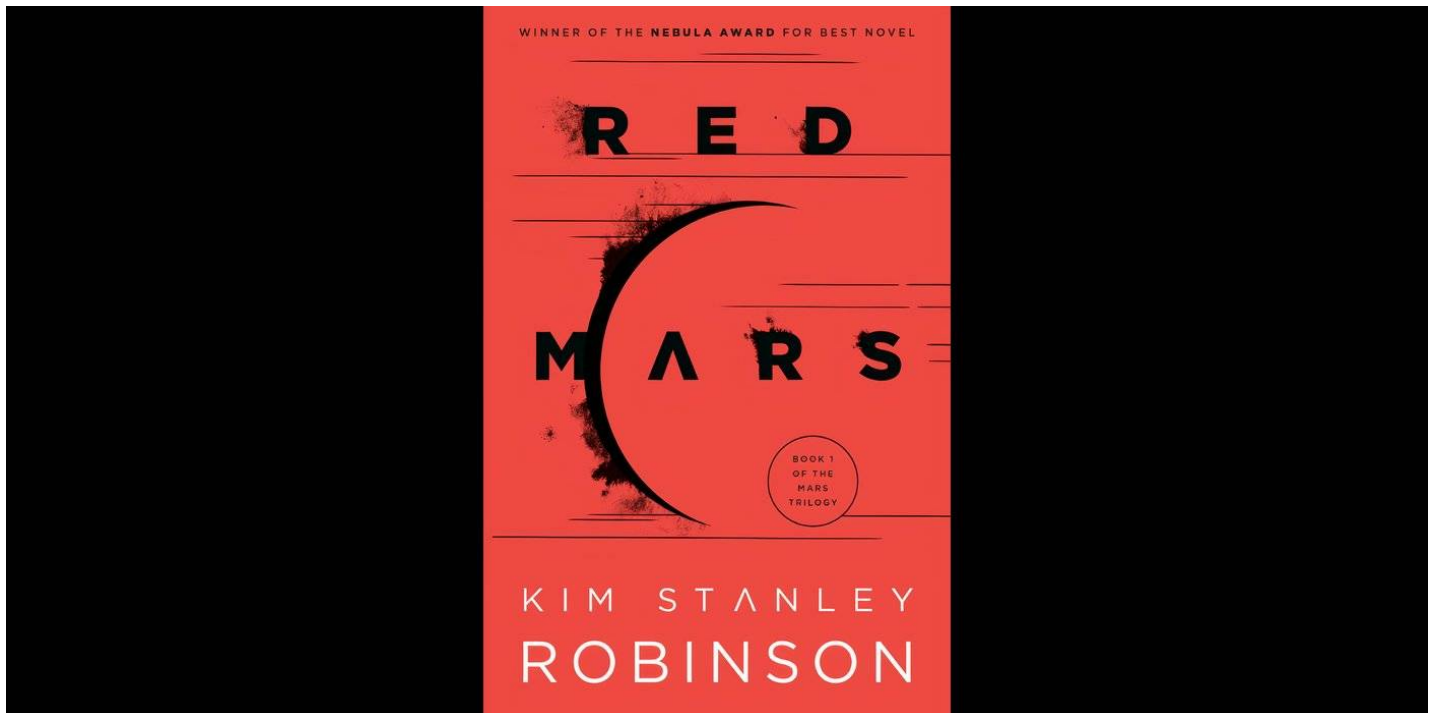


Image via Random House

"To be whole is to be part; true voyage is return." Beginning with *Red Mars* before continuing through *Green Mars* and *Blue Mars*, **Kim Stanley Robinson's** *Mars Trilogy* is perhaps the finest exploration of humanity's colonization of another planet. The series follows the First Hundred settlers who establish the first permanent colony on Mars, charting the centuries-long process of transforming the Red Planet into a world capable of supporting human life. Along the way, these pioneers must grapple with political conflict and competing visions of civilization's future.

A big part of what makes these books work is the dedication to realism, or at least plausibility. Robinson devotes enormous attention to the practical realities of terraforming without sacrificing compelling human drama. [Everything is deeply researched](#), and the canyons, volcanoes, and plains of the Red Planet are described in immersive detail. Finally, the major characters are fittingly three-dimensional and psychologically complex.

7 Imperial Radch Trilogy (2013–2015)

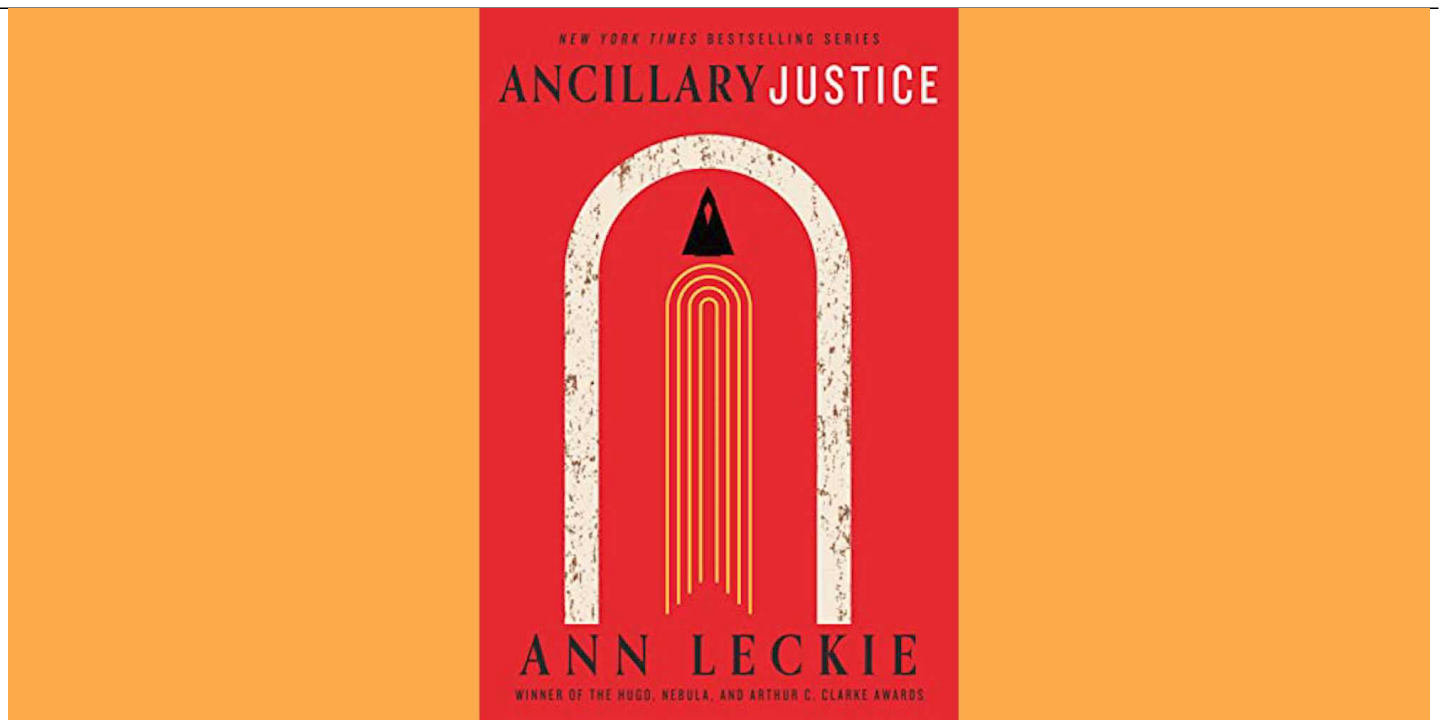
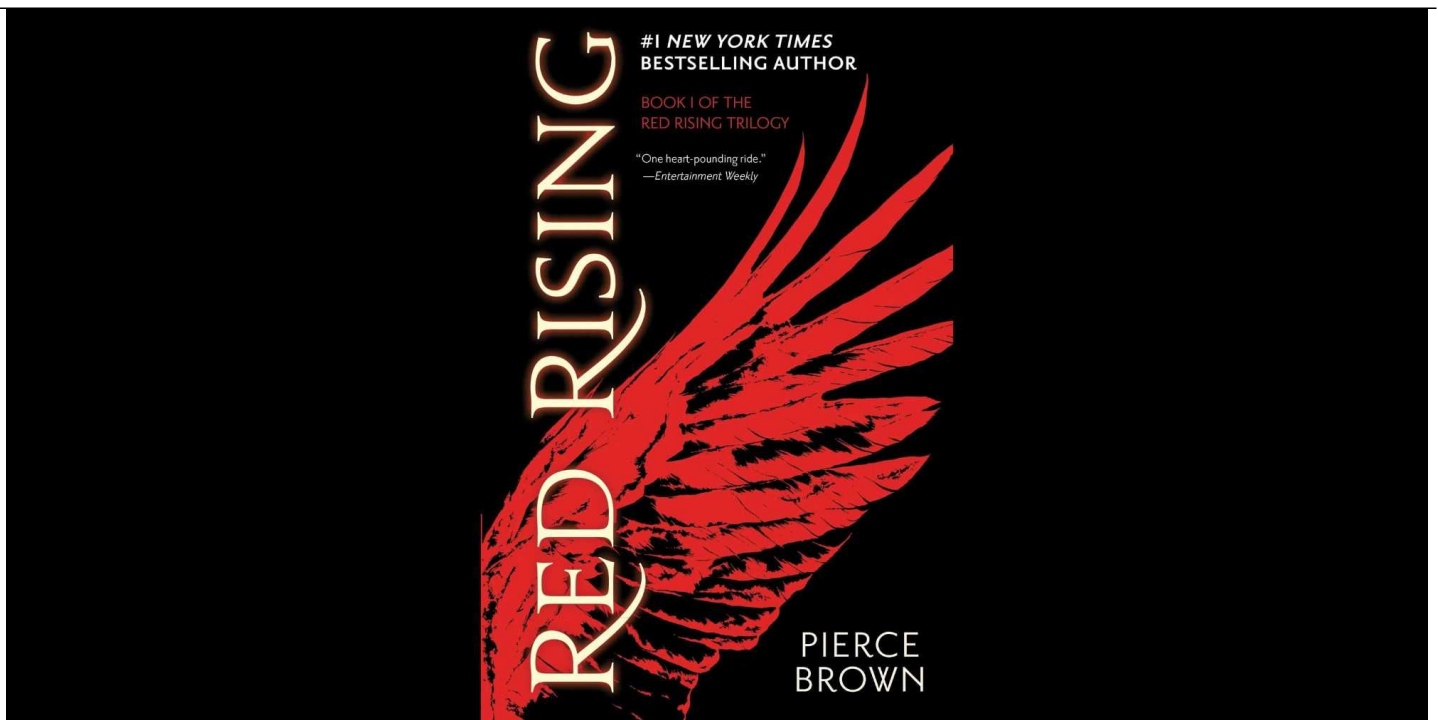


Image via Hachette Book Group

"I am not a person who matters." With *Ancillary Justice*, *Ancillary Sword*, and *Ancillary Mercy*, **Ann Leckie** reinvented the modern space opera. The trilogy centers on Breq, the lone surviving fragment of a vast AI hive mind that once controlled a warship serving the expansionist Radch Empire. Stripped of nearly all her former power, Breq embarks upon a quest for vengeance, in the process becoming entangled in a civil war that threatens the empire itself.

Breq is an intriguing protagonist, to say the least. Once existing simultaneously across thousands of bodies, she experiences individuality in profoundly unfamiliar ways, and Leckie uses her as a vehicle to **comment on identity and personhood**. The antagonist is likewise a multi-body being that adds further layers to the story, both literally and metaphorically. Refreshingly, **the story is character-driven and focuses on personal** stakes rather than the typical "blow up the galaxy" space opera tropes.

6 Red Rising Trilogy (2014–2016)



Cover of 'Red Rising' by Pierce Brown Image via Del Rey Books

"I live for the dream that my children will be born free." The original *Red Rising* trilogy is the chronicle of a revolution. We see everything [through the eyes of Darrow](#), a laborer born into the oppressed Red caste beneath the surface of Mars. After suffering a devastating personal tragedy, Darrow infiltrates the ruling Gold elite in order to dismantle the brutal color-based hierarchy that dominates the Solar System from within.

Although the beginning borrows familiar elements from dystopian YA fiction, the trilogy rapidly evolves into **an expansive, morally complicated military space opera**. The plot is loaded with tragic twists and shifting allegiances, while the combat scenes are all punchy, visceral, kinetic, blending ancient Roman tactics with high-tech weaponry, like pulse shields, razor swords, and armored grav-boots. Author **Pierce Brown** writes all this with a relentless momentum that keeps the pages turning.

5 Bas-Lag Novels (2000–2004)

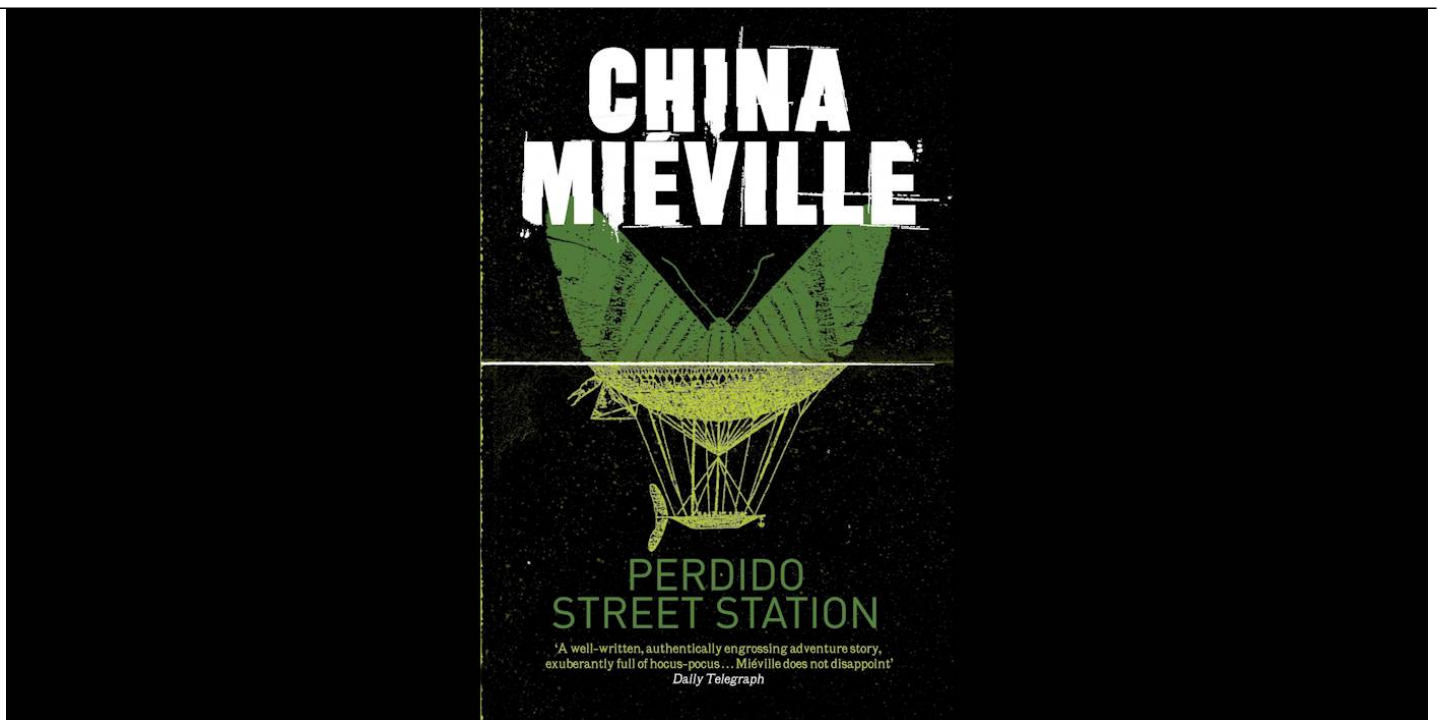
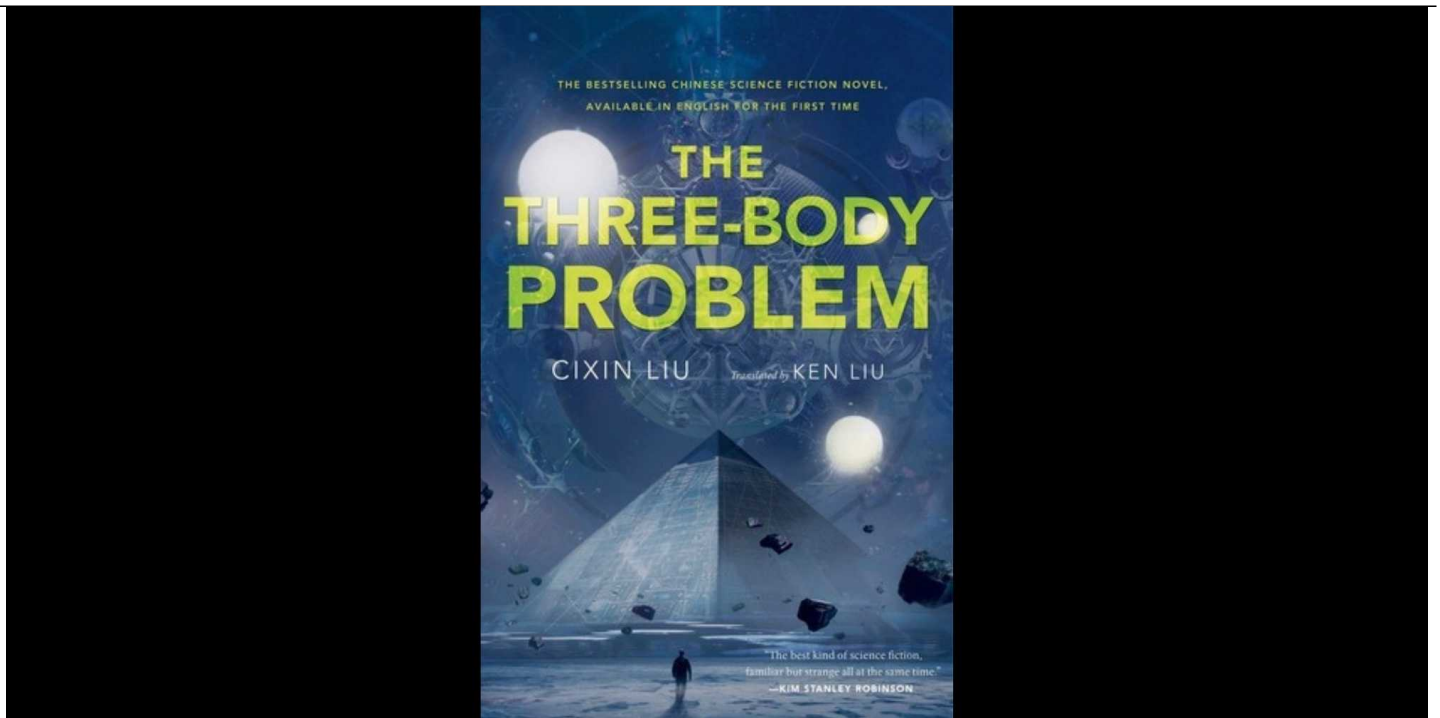


Image via Macmillan

"The city was like a vast engine dreaming." Few sci-fi trilogies are quite as bizarre or imaginative as the Bas-Lag books. Across *Perdido Street Station*, *The Scar*, and *Iron Council*, writer **China Miéville** creates a setting that gleefully ignores conventional genre boundaries. **Sci-fi mingles with fantasy, horror, steampunk, weird fiction, and political allegory.** Miéville populates this world with an astonishing assortment of creations, including golems, demons, monstrous moths, winged people known as Garuda, insect-headed ones known as Khepri, and entire pirate cities that drift across the ocean.

The trilogy's supernatural elements are equally unconventional. A type of spellcasting known as thaumaturgy functions almost like an alternate form of science, while the enigmatic magical force called the Torque can warp living bodies and even distort time itself. Stranger still is the Weaver, a godlike multidimensional being resembling an enormous spider. **It's all rather psychedelic and offbeat** but incredibly worthwhile.

4 Remembrance of Earth's Past (2006–2010)



The book cover for 'The Three-Body Problem' by Liu Cixin. Image via Tor Books

"The universe is a dark forest." Author **Liu Cixin** fired [a shot across the hard sci-fi bow](#) with *The Three-Body Problem*, then built on that foundation masterfully with follow-ups *The Dark Forest* and *Death's End*. What starts with humanity's first contact with an alien civilization gradually evolves into a breathtaking exploration of astrophysics, game theory, cosmic sociology, and the ultimate fate of intelligent life across billions of years. Talk about ambitious.

Along the way, **the series hit us with all kinds of mind-bending ideas**, like proton-sized supercomputers, aliens capable of holding entire dimensions, and a three-sun solar system that periodically inflicts apocalypse upon the aliens' home world. Yet despite all this enormous conceptual scope, the trilogy remains grounded in believable characters and compelling moral dilemmas. The TV series, overseen by **David Benioff** and **D.B. Weiss**, is solid too, and worth checking out.

3 Sprawl Trilogy (1984–1988)

WILLIAM GIBSON



The book cover of William Gibson's 'Neuromancer' Image via Ace Books

"The sky above the port was the color of television, tuned to a dead channel." Many sci-fi fans may not know this, but **William Gibson's** cyberpunk classic [Neuromancer](#) is actually the first installment in a trilogy, being followed by *Count Zero* and *Mona Lisa Overdrive*. Set in [a near-future world dominated by AI](#), sprawling megacities, and uber-powerful multinational corporations, the series follows hackers, mercenaries, artists, and criminals navigating a society transformed by cyberspace and rapidly advancing technology.

Gibson's vision proved astonishingly prophetic. Decades before the internet became central to everyday life, he was already seeing a future with imagined virtual worlds, ubiquitous digital networks, cybercrime, and the growing influence of powerful tech companies. He also coined a bunch of jargon, including the term "cyberspace" (which he fittingly described as a "consensual hallucination"). On the technical side, his **dense, lyrical, fractured prose** style perfectly captures the grim, techno-industrial atmosphere of his world.

2 Foundation Trilogy (1951–1953)

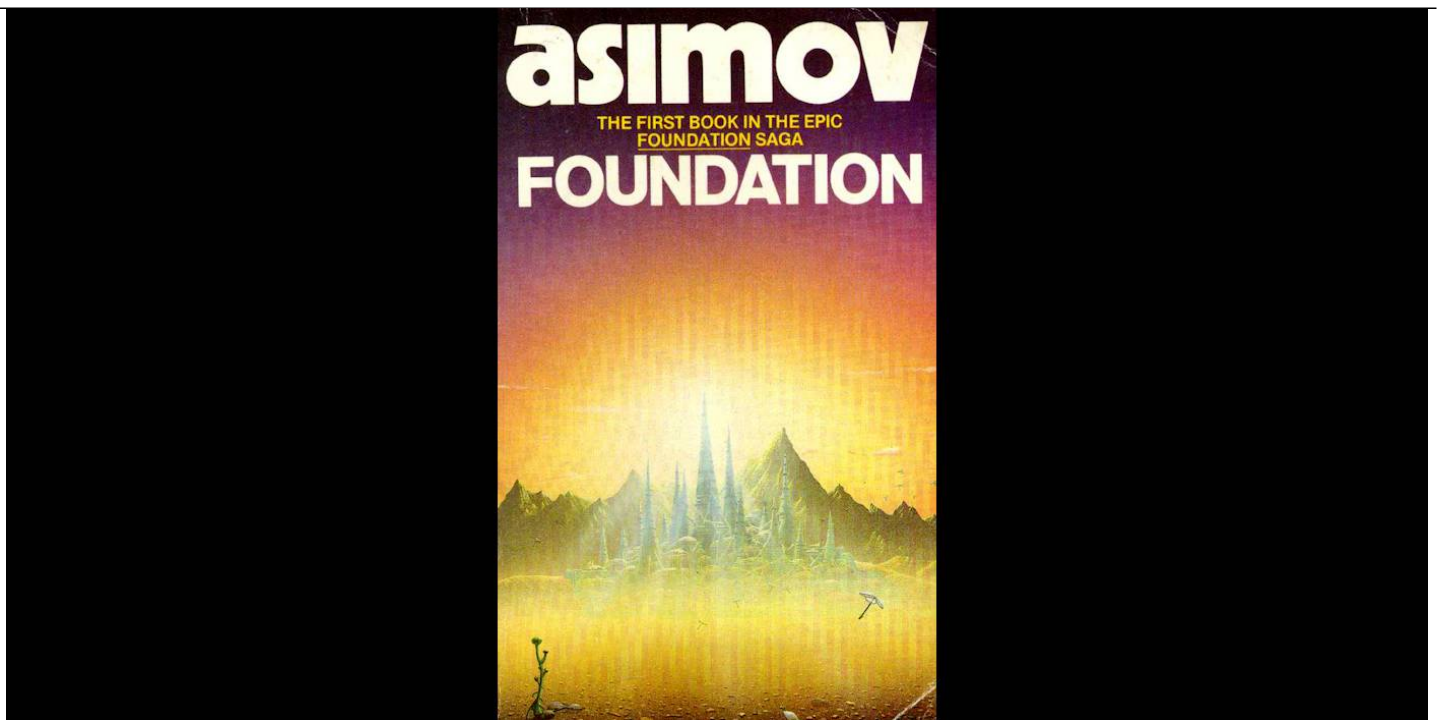


Image via Gnome Press

"Violence is the last refuge of the incompetent." This genre landmark centers on mathematician Hari Seldon, whose revolutionary science of psychohistory predicts the inevitable collapse of the Galactic Empire. Unable to prevent civilization's downfall, Seldon establishes the Foundation at the edge of the galaxy with the goal of preserving humanity's knowledge and shortening the coming dark age from thirty thousand years to just one thousand.

With this larger-than-life setup, writer **Isaac Asimov** helped establish many of the conventions of modern space opera. The most striking feature of *Foundation* is the sheer scale and scope. Rather than focusing on a single protagonist, **the trilogy unfolds across centuries**, with successive generations confronting new threats and crises. This narrative sweep was unlike any sci-fi series that had come before, breaking open **exciting new possibilities for the genre and inspiring countless fledgling writers**.

1 Dune Trilogy (1965–1969)

DUNE

FRANK HERBERT



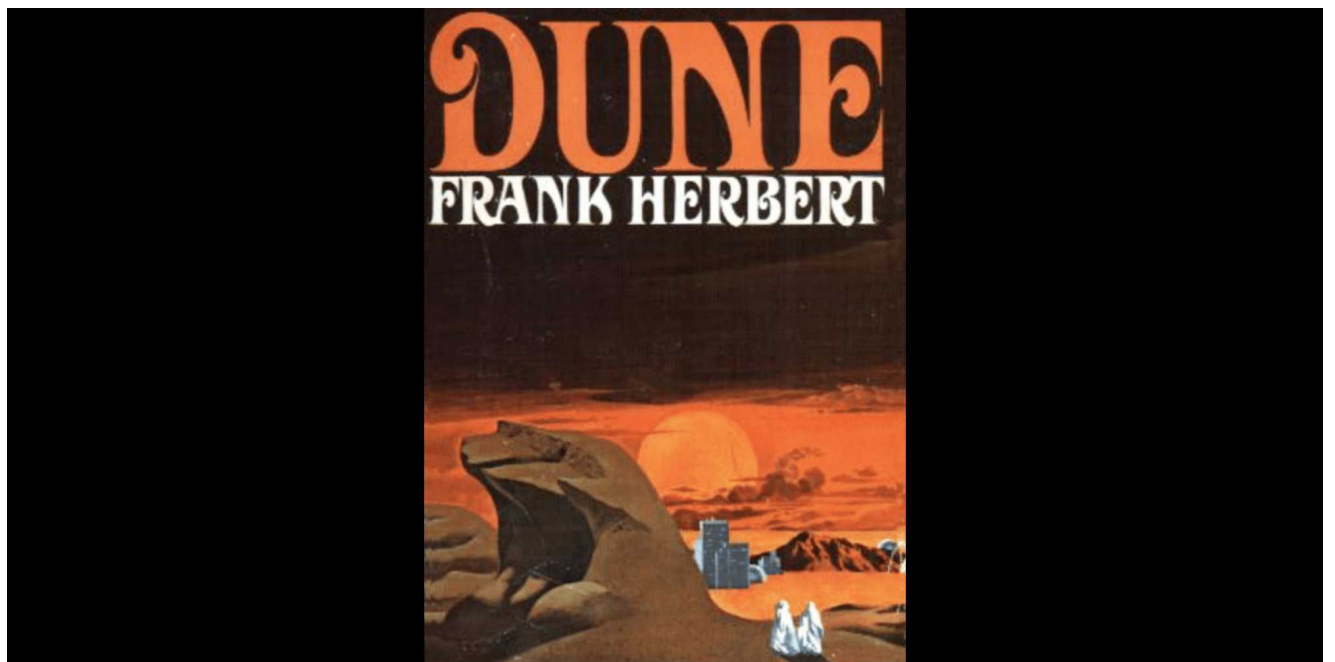
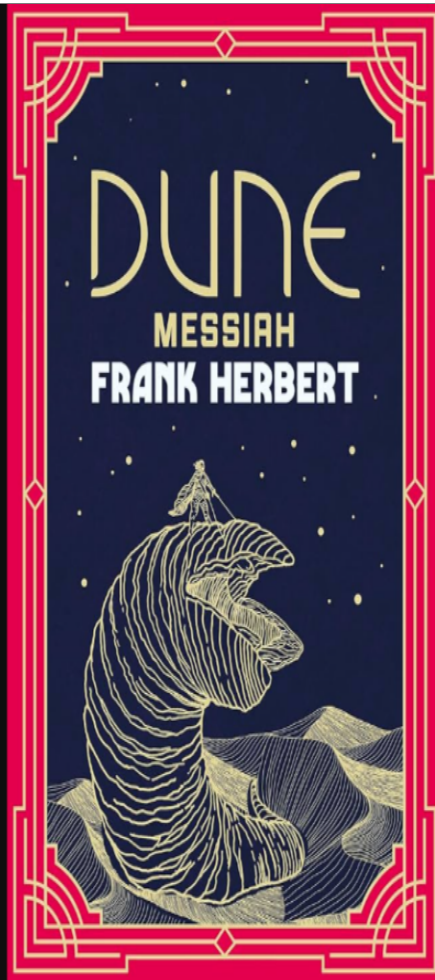


Image via Chilton Books

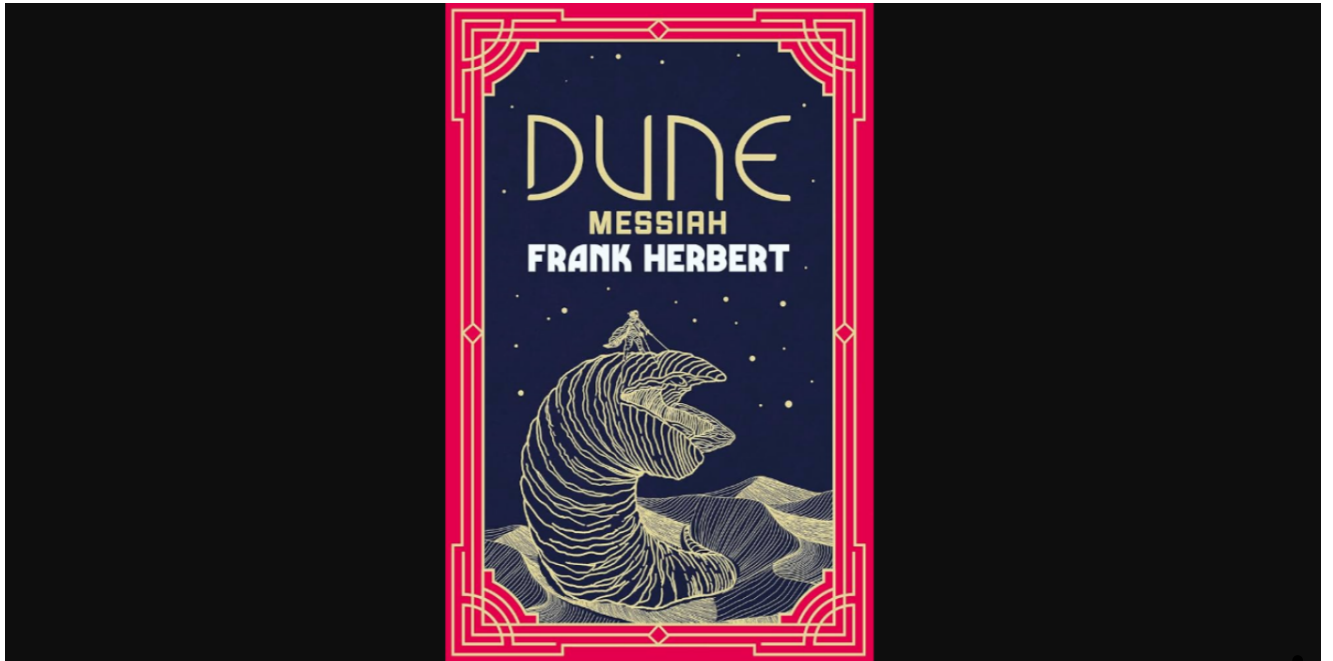


Image via Putnam Publishing

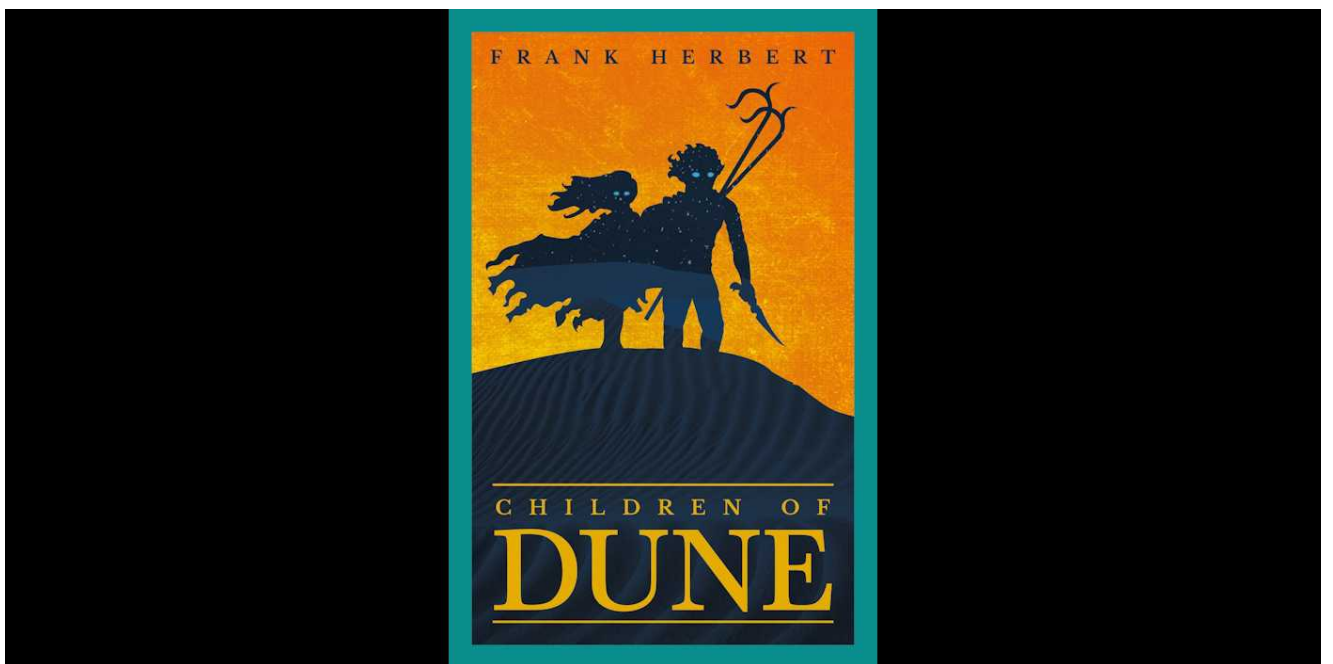


Image via HACHETTE INTL

"Fear is the mind-killer." When it comes to color, creativity, and lasting influence, it's hard to top **Frank Herbert's** original *Dune* trilogy, comprising *Dune*, *Dune Messiah*, and *Children of Dune*. Beginning on the desert planet Arrakis, the books follow Paul Atreides as he rises from dispossessed heir to messianic emperor, before examining the unforeseen consequences of his

absolute power. It's [a masterclass in intricate worldbuilding](#) and political intrigue.

While the *Dune* chronicles eventually expanded into six books, the original trilogy forms a complete, self-contained narrative arc that forever changed sci-fi by **shifting the focus from high-tech gadgets to ecology, religion, politics**, and a deconstruction of the superhero myth. Herbert does so while still immersing us in an awesome, fascinating world of mind-altering spice, strange powers, layered cultures, and terrifying sand-worms. Thanks to **Denis Villeneuve's** movie adaptations, the series once again looms large in the public consciousness.

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